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From Compliance to Collaboration: Towards a Strategic Framework for Social Sustainability in Fashion Supply Chains—Insights From a Two-Phase Literature Review

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ABSTRACT

The purpose of this study is to provide a comprehensive longitudinal analysis of the evolution of social sustainability within the global textile and fashion industry across two distinct regulatory eras: post-Multifibre Agreement (2005–2018) and post-Modern Slavery Act (2019–2023). Using a PRISMA-based systematic literature review of 140 Scopus-indexed studies, it integrates bibliometric co-word analysis through VOSviewer and thematic content analysis via NVivo. The findings reveal a notable transition from compliance-oriented corporate social responsibility to collaborative, technology-enabled approaches to social governance. Paradoxically, while emerging technologies such as blockchain, RFID, and AI-driven traceability systems enhance transparency, they can also reproduce existing power asymmetries by deepening supplier dependence and buyer control. This dual-edged impact underscores that innovation without inclusion may reinforce inequity rather than resolve it. The study identifies a parallel evolution in governance, from voluntary codes and audits to multi-stakeholder, legislated accountability frameworks, that collectively redefine social responsibility in fashion supply chains. Anchored in Institutional and Stakeholder Theories, the study develops a two-by-two conceptual framework capturing the strategic shift from compliance to collaboration. It advances CSR and ESG scholarship by offering testable propositions linking institutional pressures, stakeholder engagement, and technological innovation. The paper provides actionable insights for policymakers and fashion enterprises pursuing socially sustainable transformation within global supply chains.

1 | Introduction

The global fashion industry, involving creativity, commerce, and consumption, is also one of the most socially contested sectors in the world, notorious for labour abuses. Its rapid growth has been propelled by population expansion, consumerism, and the relentless demand for affordable clothing (Abbate et al. 2023; Brewer 2019). However, this very expansion has precipitated serious social and ethical challenges. The shift of manufacturing to developing countries, motivated by cost efficiency, has produced fragmented and opaque supply chains that rely on cheap labour and often exploit vulnerable workers (Köksal et al. 2018; Soundararajan and Brammer 2018). The prevalence of poor working conditions, precarious employment, and labour exploitation exposes deep-rooted governance failures and the moral costs of globalisation (Egels-Zandén and Lindholm 2015; Islam and Deegan 2008).

Notable incidents, like the collapse of the Rana Plaza building in 2013 resulting in over 1100 deaths (Siddiqui and Uddin 2016) as well as international scandals such as a documentary by British Channel 4 exposing substandard working

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conditions such as long working hours, minimal day offs, and insufficient wages, in factories operated by Shein, a Chinese ultra-fast fashion company, have transformed public discourse (Edwards 2024). These crises have forced policymakers, investors, and consumers to confront the human consequences of fashion's accelerated production models. Consequently, social sustainability, which we define as the pursuit of fairness, equity, and human rights in supply chains, has emerged as a central pillar of sustainable fashion debates (Rana et al. 2024; Smestad 2009; Stringer and Michailova 2018). Yet, progress remains uneven and fragmented, with human rights abuses continuing to occur, and firms frequently prioritising short-term economic efficiency over long-term ethical transformation (Majumdar and Sinha 2020).

While economic and environmental performance can be easily quantified through metrics like CO_2 emissions, measuring social performance remains elusive (Dickson and Eckman 2008; Fadara and Wong 2022). Social indicators are often indirect, context-specific, and vary across countries, making the process of measurement and reporting more challenging (Tuppura et al. 2016; Winter and Lasch 2016). This measurement challenge demonstrates why much of the earlier sustainability literature remained confined to the Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) paradigm, focusing on voluntary initiatives rather than enforceable accountability mechanisms. However, as institutional pressures have intensified through regulatory and stakeholder activism, the discourse has shifted towards Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) frameworks and circular economy models that seek to embed ethics within operational systems.

The fashion industry experienced significant regulatory changes with the abolition of the Multifiber Arrangement (MFA) in 2005 and the introduction of Modern Slavery Acts (MSA) in the mid-to-late 2010s. The end of MFA deregulated textile trade, leading to the relocation of production to countries with lower labour costs but weaker institutional oversight, exacerbating social risks (Velázquez et al. 2008). Conversely, MSAs in 2015 (UK Home Office 2015) and 2018 (Parliament of Australia 2018), alongside emerging due diligence legislations such as Germany's Supply Chain Act (2021) and the EU's Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive (2024), represent a shift towards mandatory transparency, forcing firms to report on human rights and labour standards (Nolan and Frishling 2019; European Commission 2024). This transition from deregulation to enforced accountability has catalysed new research on corporate behaviour, stakeholder engagement, and governance systems.

Existing studies (Fontana et al. 2023; Haque and Azmat 2015; Huq et al. 2014; Wu et al. 2023; Zhang and Chen 2023) have largely focused on significant aspects of social sustainability such as labour rights, working conditions, supply chain ethics, consumer awareness and regulatory pressures but limited studies adopt a temporal or comparative approach that spans distinct regulatory eras. While isolated works examine CSR implementation or modern slavery compliance, a comprehensive analysis comparing pre- and post-MFA/MSA periods is notably scarce. This review, therefore, contributes by mapping the thematic and conceptual evolution of social sustainability across two decades (2005–2018 and 2019–2023), revealing how the fashion industry's strategies have shifted from compliance-driven models to collaborative and innovation-led approaches.

This study positions the evolution of social sustainability within two complementary theoretical frameworks that include Institutional Theory and Stakeholder Theory. Institutional Theory explains how regulatory pressures, industry norms, and societal expectations drive organisational conformity to legitimacy standards (DiMaggio and Powell 1983). In contrast, Stakeholder Theory explains how organisations balance diverse interests through engagement, collaboration, and shared value creation (Freeman 1984). Together, these perspectives provide a dynamic lens to interpret the fashion industry's transformation, from reactive compliance under institutional pressure to proactive collaboration through stakeholder partnerships. This dual-theoretical approach enables a holistic understanding of how regulation and relational governance jointly shape the trajectory of social sustainability.

This study aims to examine the longitudinal evolution of social sustainability in the global fashion and textile supply chain by comparing two regulatory eras, the post-MFA period (2005–2018) and the post-MSA period (2019–2023). It seeks to integrate fragmented literature streams (CSR, ESG, governance, technology, and circular economy) into a cohesive framework that explains how regulatory, technological, and collaborative mechanisms have collectively redefined social responsibility in the fashion industry, through the lenses of Institutional Theory and Stakeholder Theory.

Therefore, this study focuses on the following two key research questions:

RQ1. *How have key regulatory changes (the 2005 abolition of the Multifibre Arrangement and the post-2018 introduction of Modern Slavery Acts) influenced the evolution of social sustainability practices in fashion and textile supply chains?*

RQ2. *What emerging trends, persistent issues, and research gaps in social sustainability are evident in the fashion supply chain literature when comparing the 2005–2018 period to 2019–2023, and how can these inform future practices and policies?*

The remainder of this paper is structured as follows: Section 2 delineates the study's methodology. Section 3 outlines the descriptive analysis. Section 4 synthesises the thematic findings across two distinct periods. Section 5 presents the discussion and implications. The paper finally presents the conclusions and acknowledges the limitations in Section 6.

2 | Research Methodology

To systematically examine the evolution of social sustainability within the fashion and textile supply chains, this study adopted a mixed-method approach that integrates bibliometric co-word analysis with qualitative thematic analysis. This dual strategy enabled both a quantitative mapping of core research themes and a qualitative analysis of their contextual depth and evolution over time. The review process was guided by the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses

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(PRISMA) framework to ensure transparency, rigour, and replicability (Tranfield et al. 2003). By integrating VOSviewer for bibliometric network visualisation and NVivo for inductive coding, this study provides a robust analytical foundation for uncovering thematic developments across two key regulatory periods, while maintaining methodological clarity in study selection, data synthesis, and interpretation. We use the methodology recommended by Kitchenham et al. (2009) and Higgins (2008); outlined below.

2.1 | Search Strategy

To collect relevant information for our research, we conducted a comprehensive search across the Scopus database. Scopus is highly recognised for its broad collection of peer-reviewed literature in the social sciences domain. It also provides better search functionalities that facilitate accurate identification of academic publications. The use of a single data base mitigates variances in data extraction and citation metrics, which can differ across various data bases (Harzing and Alakangas 2017; Terán-Yépez et al. 2020). Such uniformity is vital for maintaining the reliability of bibliometric analyses (Gusenbauer and Haddaway 2020; Mongeon and Paul-Hus 2016). Finally, Scopus adeptly integrates bibliometric tools and software such as VOS Viewer, which we employed for our analysis. This integration facilitates the process of data extraction and analysis, thereby improving the efficiency and accuracy of our bibliometric and thematic investigations.

The Scopus search was conducted using relevant keywords and Boolean queries. To capture a wide variety of published articles in the fashion social sustainability domain, we have developed a comprehensive three-level keyword assembly structure. Level one focuses on the Textile, Clothing and Fashion (TCF) industry keywords, level two encompasses keywords related to sustainability, and level three includes social context keywords related to the subject matter. The keyword search includes publication keywords, title and abstract in the Scopus database.

Textile, Clothing, and fashion industry keywords: 'textile*' OR 'fashion industry*' OR 'cloth*' OR 'apparel*' OR 'garment*' OR 'fast fashion' OR 'ready-to-wear' OR 'fashion retail' OR 'fashion supplier*' OR 'TAF' OR 'direct-to-consumer' OR 'textile industry*' OR 'garment manufactur*' OR 'textile manufactur*' OR 'textile sector' OR 'garment produc*' OR 'fashion produc*' OR 'textile produc*'.

Sustainability keywords: 'sustainability' OR 'sustainable development' OR 'sustainable fashion' OR 'sustainable cloth*' OR 'sustainab* trend*' OR 'ethical fashion' OR 'triple bottom line' OR 'corporate social responsibility*' OR 'CSR' OR 'fashion supply chain' OR 'green supply chain' OR 'green washing'.

Social context keywords: 'low-paid worker' OR 'fair salary' OR 'unfair wage' OR 'unsafe work* environment' OR 'low labour cost' OR 'Social* sustainab*' OR 'poor work* condition*' OR 'social ethics' OR 'child labour' OR 'forced labour' OR 'cheap labour' OR 'labour intensive' OR 'gender discrimination' OR 'gender *equality' OR 'un-healthy work* environment' OR 'dangerous working environment' OR 'inhuman treatment' OR 'excessive work* hour*' OR 'sustainable sourcing' OR 'socially responsible sourcing' OR 'SRS' OR 'equitable society' OR 'social equity' OR 'social impact' OR 'community development' OR 'ethical issues' OR 'societal pressure' OR 'social performance' OR 'social benefit' OR 'living conditions' OR 'work-life balance' OR 'women empowerment' OR 'education and healthcare' OR 'vulnerable labour' OR 'vulnerable employment' OR 'vulnerable worker' OR 'weak regulation' OR 'labour violation' OR 'illegal working condition' OR 'women discrimination' OR 'gender based violence' OR 'social welfare' OR 'modern slavery' OR 'migrant worker' OR 'human rights due diligence' OR 'social life cycle assessment' OR 'ESG'.

2.2 | Study Selection

We focussed on the papers in peer-reviewed journals from the year 2005 to 2023 in English, excluding books, book chapters, and non-refereed publications. The exclusion of grey literature, books, and non-refereed sources was deliberate to ensure the consistency and quality of the analysed data. Grey literature often varies in methodological rigour, citation standards, and accessibility, which may introduce inconsistency and potential bias in bibliometric mapping (Adams et al. 2017). Limiting the dataset to peer-reviewed journal articles thus ensures that the included studies meet recognised academic standards and are comparable across analytical dimensions. We found only 14 relevant articles from 1990 to 2004, indicating that academic attention to social sustainability in fashion was relatively scant before 2005, and significantly increased after the MFA's abolition. We excluded sources post-2023 due to insufficient citation time, relevance to our data timeframe and ensuring that analysis covers the evolution of the topic (Snyder 2019). Additionally, by 2023 the research topic is considered relatively mature, meaning key themes and patterns can be discerned without the confounding influence of growing 2024 studies (Boell and Cecez-Kecmanovic 2015; Tranfield et al. 2003).

This initial search resulted in a total of 526 documents. To ensure the highest level of methodical rigour and to define clear boundaries to delimit the research, we followed a two-step process (Centobelli et al. 2017; Cerchione and Esposito 2016; Greenhalgh 1997). First, we focused on the papers in peer-reviewed journals from the year 2005 to 2023 in English, aiming to exclude the articles in any other language. Second, we narrowed down our selection to only those categorised under business, management and accounting, social sciences, decision sciences, arts and humanities, and multidisciplinary, due to their pertinence to the focus and embeddedness of our study. This resulted in 221 shortlisted articles. Figure 1 shows study selection criteria using the PRISMA framework.

During the title and abstract screening, we further excluded articles that did not exactly address social sustainability in a fashion supply chain context. For instance, papers focusing purely on environmental sustainability (with no social dimension), or on general supply chain management without a clear connection to the fashion industry, were set aside as not relevant. After this, we carefully screened the abstracts of all shortlisted articles to ensure inclusion of only those papers that specifically address social sustainability in the textile and fashion industry (Pittaway et al. 2004). Two researchers separately examined the abstracts

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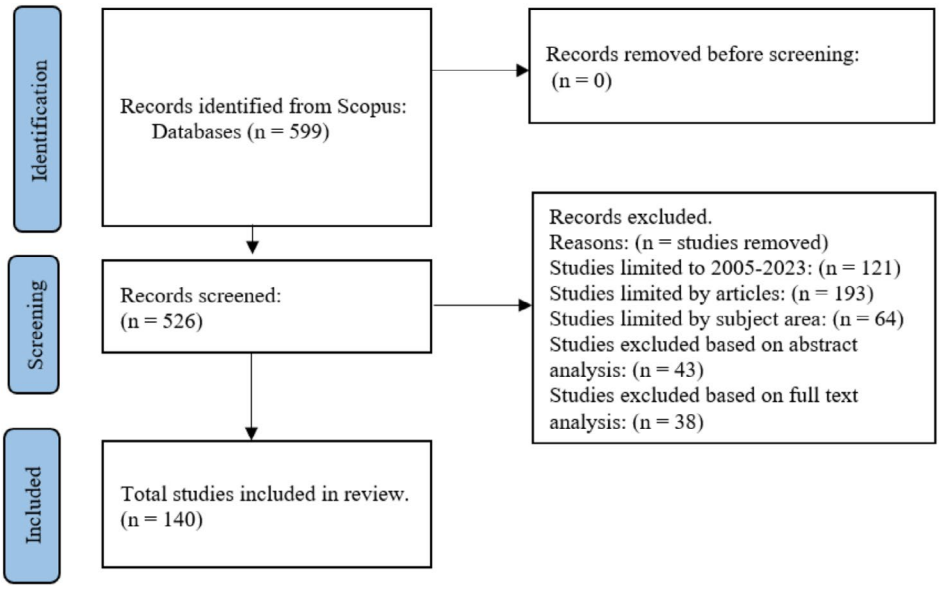


FIGURE 1 | PRISMA flow diagram of study selection process.

to eliminate subjective bias, with a third researcher reconciling any doubts (Cerchione and Esposito 2016). This process led to the exclusion of 43 papers. A full text analysis of the remaining 178 articles was conducted, and an additional 38 papers were excluded that were not relevant to the current research area. Finally, 140 papers met the criteria and thus became the basis of this review.

2.3 | Data Extraction and Synthesis

To analyse the intellectual landscape and emerging themes within the selected literature, this study conducted a co-word bibliometric analysis with the software VOSviewer. Co-word analysis represents a systematic approach in content analysis that uses keywords obtained from the documents to delineate scientific landscapes within a particular field (He 1999). In this study, the unit of co-word analysis is 'All keywords' in the publications with each keyword serving as nodes. The links between the nodes represent the instances where the keywords appear together in the paper. Larger nodes indicate a higher frequency of keyword occurrence, while the thickness of the link denotes increased co-occurrence of keywords together (Van Eck et al. 2010). This analysis helps to identify the relationships between keywords, and the network map provides a visual representation of both the frequency and patterns of co-occurrence (Donthu et al. 2021). The frequency of co-occurring terms likely signifies related or trending research topics. In constructing the co-word network, we set a minimum occurrence threshold of at least 5 occurrences (i.e., the keyword appears in 5 or more of the 140 articles) for a term to be included in the analysis (Chai and Xiao 2012; Zupic and Čater 2015). This means that only keywords used by multiple studies were mapped. The five-occurrence threshold was established through exploratory trials. This helped successfully identify prevalent topics across numerous papers while disregarding unique keywords that fail to reflect broader themes. Common terms such as 'sustainability', 'supply chain', 'corporate social responsibility', and 'labour practices' were frequently observed and exceeded the threshold. This thresholding resulted in a concise collection of keywords that reflect the thematic lexicon characteristic of the domain.

Following the bibliometric mapping, inductive thematic analysis was conducted on the selected articles using NVivo. This analysis aimed to further examine and interpret the thematic clusters identified by the co-word analysis, adding contextual depth and validating the nature of those themes through qualitative insights (Bazeley 2007). While the co-word analysis systematically identified themes of related keywords that is, 'manifest content', the NVivo analysis facilitated an in-depth investigation of content within the articles, thus capturing nuances and underlying narratives that a keyword network alone cannot fully convey, or 'latent content' (Dooley 2016). The abstracts of articles within themes obtained from co-word analysis were imported into NVivo for thematic analysis. A systematic coding approach was adopted, wherein initial codes were generated based on the content and later refined through an interactive process into broader thematic constructs. The synthesis involved a thorough integration of findings obtained from both bibliometric and thematic analysis.

The combination of quantitative co-word analysis and qualitative thematic analysis provided a robust mixed-method framework. Initially, VOSviewer presented a data-driven overview of the research domain, highlighting significant themes and their interrelations. Consequently, NVivo provided a comprehensive analysis of these themes, validating their importance and expanding on their details. This methodological sequence is rigorous as it aligns objectively with interpretation; the co-word network reduces researcher bias by enabling data to reveal themes, while inductive coding reinstates expert judgement to contextualise these themes within existing literature. This approach substantiates that the findings of this review are both empirically validated and contextually significant.

A comparative analysis was conducted on the co-occurrence of keywords during two specific periods: 2005–2018 (after

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the abolition of the MFA and before the introduction of the Australian MSA) and 2019–2023 (after the implementation of the MSA). Due to the difficulty and inefficiency of analysing a total of 649 keywords identified during 2005–2018 and 1244 from 2019 to 2023, a threshold of at least 5 occurrences in articles was set (Zupic and Čater 2015; Chai and Xiao 2012). As a result, 15 keywords were obtained for the 2005–2018 period and 45 for the 2019–2023 period.

3 | Descriptive Analysis

Figure 2 describes the distribution of publications overtime, across journals, by countries, and keyword frequency between two eras. A comprehensive analysis of 140 selected scholarly articles reveals substantial growth in research related to social sustainability within the textile and clothing (TCF) industry from 2005 to 2023. This increase has been notably evident after 2018, with around 68% of articles published between the last 5 years (2018–2023).

The journals with most related studies include *Sustainability* which has published 22 papers contributing 8.91% of the reviewed articles, closely followed by *Journal of Cleaner Production* with 20 articles. Additional noteworthy contributions are found in *Journal of Fashion Marketing and Management*, *International Journal of Production Economics*, *Journal of Business Ethics*, *Supply Chain Management*, and *International Journal of Fashion Design Technology and Education*. All aforementioned journals are categorised within the top quartile (Q1) based on the SCImago Journal Rank (SJR), emphasising their significant contribution within this domain.

The most productive nations within the research domain were found to be the United Kingdom leading this ranking with 40 scholarly contributions closely trailed by the USA (36), and China (30). It is worth noting that certain papers were collaboratively written by researchers from different countries, while others were co-authored by individuals of the same nationality. Conversely, in cases where two or more researchers from a single country co-authored a paper, their country is counted only once. Figure 2 illustrates the countries that produced a minimum of 10 articles pertaining to social sustainability between 2005 and 2023.

The analysis of keyword frequencies between the periods 2005–2018 and 2019–2023 reveals a consistent usage pattern in both titles and abstracts. There has been a significant rise in the prominence and recurrence of terms associated with sustainability, supply chains, social sustainability, and consumer behaviour. Conversely, conventional subjects such as production and textiles have declined in prominence despite their increased mentions, suggesting a transition towards more interconnected and multifaceted topics within the field. Additionally, keywords pertaining to fashion and stakeholders have surfaced, indicating new domains of interest and academic inquiry. 'Corporate Social Responsibility' disappeared from the recent data, suggesting its integration into broader terms like 'Social Impact'. Keywords like 'Supplier' and 'Social Sustainability' significantly improved in rank, indicating their rising prominence in recent research discussions. The keyword 'consumer' stands out for its implications concerning an upstream drive for maintaining social sustainability advocated by consumers.

4 | Analysis

This section addresses Research Question 1 (RQ1), which examines how social sustainability practices in the fashion industry have evolved across two key regulatory periods. Drawing on coword and thematic analyses of the selected literature, the section traces the shift from compliance-oriented approaches dominant in the post-MFA era (2005–2018) to more collaborative, technology-enabled, and multi-stakeholder models emerging in the post-MSA era (2019–2023). By mapping the evolution of key themes and institutional drivers, it highlights the mechanisms through which regulatory, technological, and stakeholder influences have redefined social sustainability governance within global fashion supply chains.

4.1 | Emerging Research Themes: Period 2005–2018

Between the years 2005 and 2018, three distinct thematic clusters have emerged as shown in Figure 3. The critical summary of each thematic cluster is given below:

4.1.1 | Cluster 1—Integrating Social Sustainability in Fashion and Textiles

Cluster 1 explores the ways to integrate social sustainability across the fashion supply chain, revealing an ongoing struggle between ethical imperatives and economic objectives. Achieving this integration requires harnessing innovation, conducting comprehensive life cycle assessments, fostering stakeholder collaboration and developing equitable business models. Li and Wu (2017) highlight that the fashion industry continues to struggle with balancing profitability and ethical practices, suggesting that true integration requires a deeper structural shift rather than superficial initiatives. Conversely, Winter and Lasch (2016) identified an increasing trend to incorporate social, ethical and environmental criteria in supplier selection; however, there is a notable discrepancy between theory and practice in applying sustainability criteria, signifying a gap between aspirations and real-world practices. Bly et al. (2015) and Niinimäki and Hassi (2011) show that there is a growing shift towards slow fashion, with consumers opting for sustainable and long-lifetime garments. However, mainstream fashion still struggles to align with these consumer values, reflecting a disjunction between consumer values and business models. Roos et al. (2016) and Lenzo et al. (2018) emphasised the importance of embedding sustainability throughout the fashion supply chain. They advocate for the adoption of Life cycle assessments (LCA) and Social LCA frameworks, in conjunction with stakeholder collaboration. This approach presents a promising yet underutilised pathway for integrating social and environmental goals within production systems. The evidence suggests that without cohesive policy frameworks, consumer awareness, and transparent communication (Bürklin 2019; Da Giau et al. 2016), such initiatives risk remaining symbolic. Therefore, scaling sustainability requires transformative innovation and business models (Todeschini et al. 2017) that internalise social

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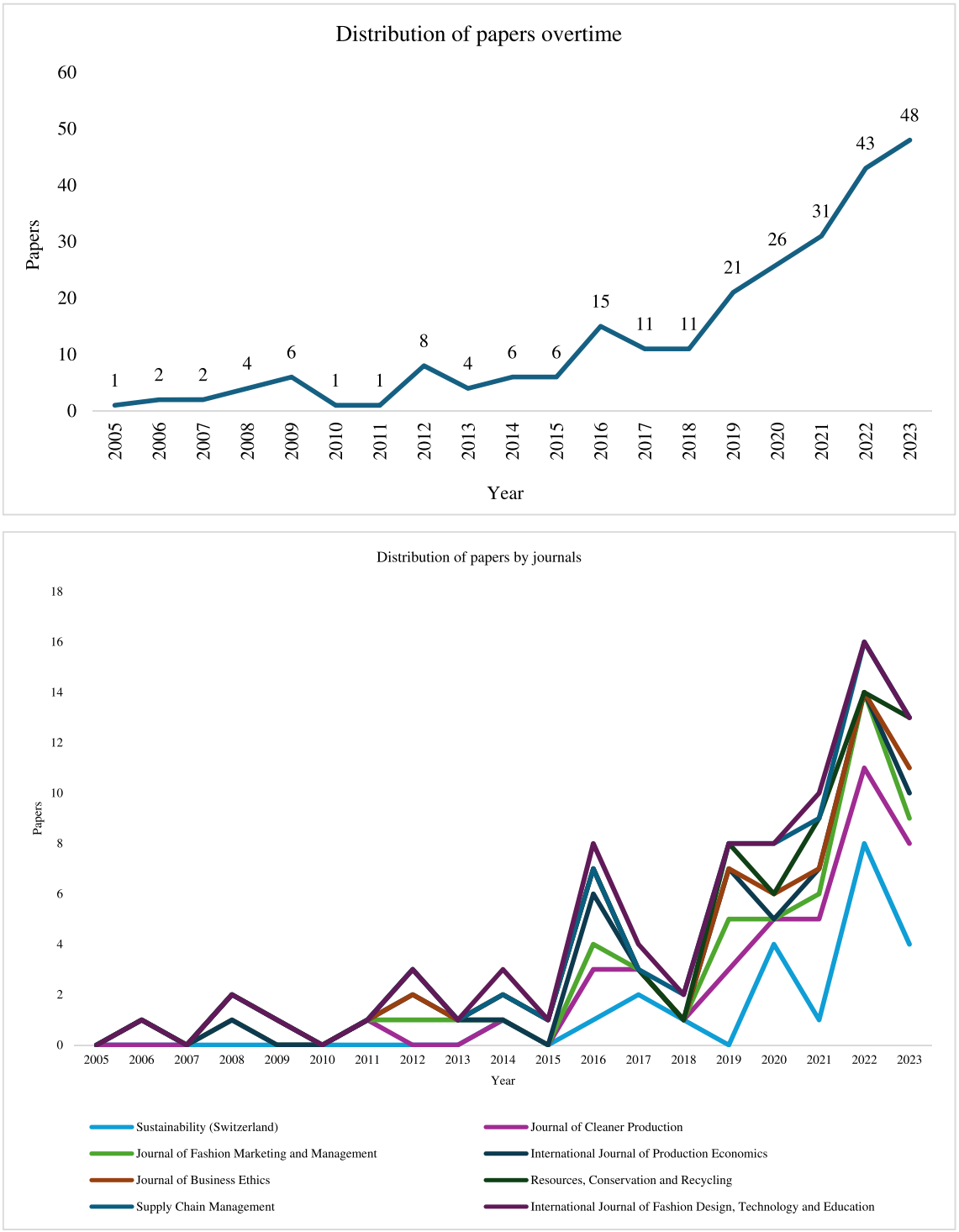


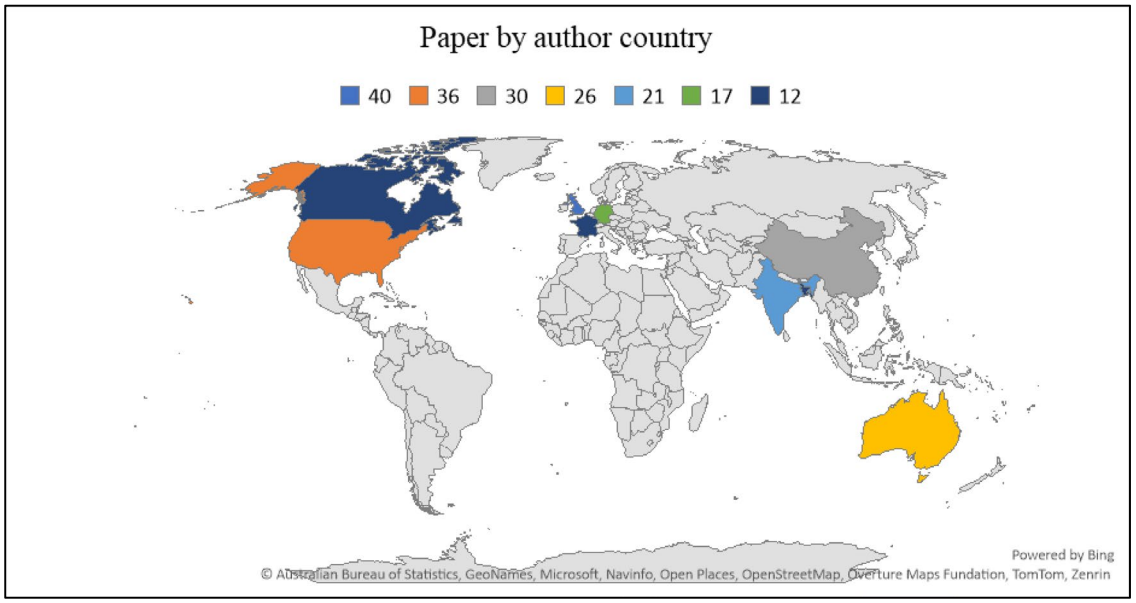
FIGURE 2 | Distribution of paper overtime, by journals, by author country and keyword frequency.

costs and position ethical production as a central, not peripheral, element of corporate competitiveness.

4.1.2 | Cluster 2—Aligning Profitability With Ethical Responsibility

Cluster 2 examines the persistent tension between profitability and ethical responsibility in the global fashion industry, revealing that corporate claims of responsibility often mask deeper structural inequities. These systemic challenges include but are not limited to unfair labour practices, child labour, and cultural misalignments in the globally dispersed fashion supply chain. While CSR initiatives have proven effective in enhancing stakeholder relationships and brand reputation (Arrigo 2013), they frequently fail to deliver substantive change in regions with weak institutional enforcement, such as Bangladesh (Huq and Stevenson 2020; Haque and Azmat 2015). This underscores the need for stronger governance and collaborative frameworks that embed ethics within the economic logic of fashion production.

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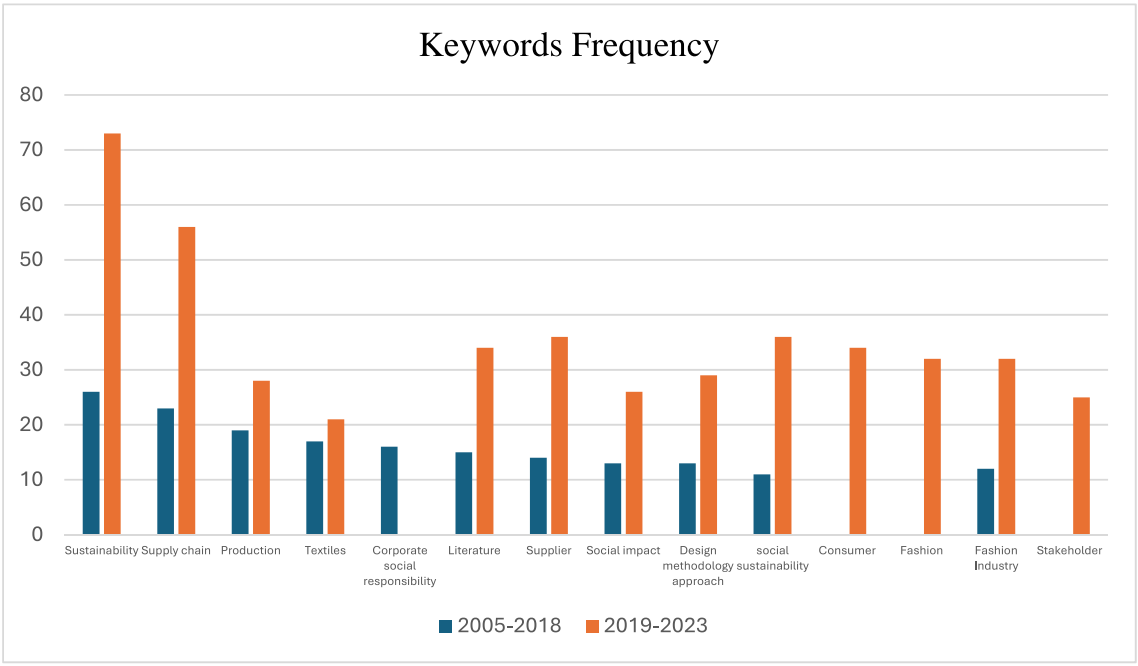


FIGURE 2 | (Continued)

Building trust, ensuring transparency, and fostering innovation are not optional but necessary conditions for meaningful reform. Collaborative approaches such as horizontal partnerships and co-design strategies can facilitate shared accountability and equitable value distribution (Benstead et al. 2018). Crucial steps to achieve social sustainability goals include working with suppliers to improve their perception, changing customer behaviour as ethical concerns are often secondary to personal preferences (Joergens 2006; Shen et al. 2012), and addressing cultural and regulatory factors (Baskaran et al. 2011; Normann et al. 2017).

4.1.3 | Cluster 3—Power Dynamics and Innovation

Cluster 3 examines the pursuit of equitable relationships in multi-tier fashion supply chains, where power asymmetries and fragmented governance continue to challenge the realisation of social sustainability. Research in this area argues that power imbalances between buyers and suppliers undermine ethical progress, necessitating structural collaboration rather than transactional control. Perry et al. (2015) highlight that effective collaboration can reduce power disparities, while Köksal et al. (2018) emphasise the crucial role of intermediaries in building trust and ensuring compliance between retailers and factories. Yet, the dispersed nature of production often complicates these efforts, as worker safety and environmental performance vary considerably by region (Cao et al. 2014; Clarke-Sather and Cobb 2019). Wilhelm et al. (2016) argue that supply chain complexity and limited first-tier supplier capabilities restrict the diffusion of sustainability across deeper tiers, leaving systemic risks unaddressed. Hannibal and Kauppi (2019) point out that third-party checks

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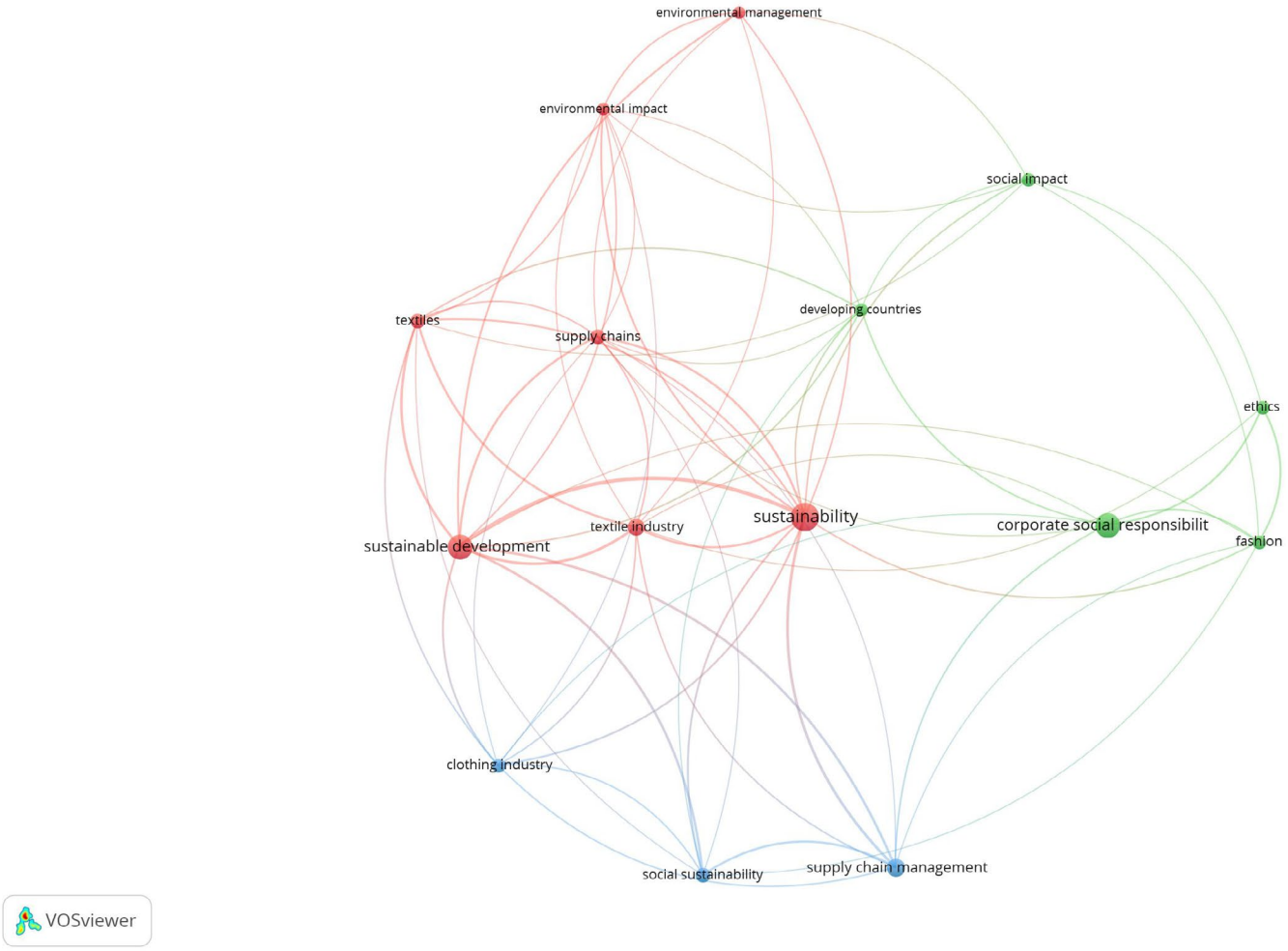


FIGURE 3 | The cluster diagram of co-occurrence of keywords between 2005 and 2018.

vary significantly, leaving supply chain members at risk due to their undefined roles. This shows that multi-tier sustainability is crucial but often hampered by inconsistent execution and oversight. These findings reinforce that multi-tier sustainability requires coherent regulatory alignment and cross-level collaboration. Strengthening monitoring mechanisms, clarifying responsibilities, and adopting collaborative frameworks are therefore essential for systemic reform (Burchielli et al. 2009; Clarke-Sather and Cobb 2019). Macchion et al. (2018) presented three approaches to enhance social and environmental sustainability that include reactive, proactive, and value-seeking approaches. In addition, Social Hotspot Database (SHDB) (Benoit-Norris et al. 2012), collaborative consumption models (Joyner Armstrong and Park 2017), and ethical networks (Burchielli et al. 2009) provide practical pathways to identify social risks and embed equity-driven innovation across supply chains.

4.2 | Emerging Research Themes: Period 2019–2023

Between the years 2019 and 2023, four distinct thematic research clusters have emerged as shown in Figure 4. The critical summary of each thematic cluster is given below:

4.2.1 | Cluster 1—Tech-Enabled Transparency for Social Equity

Cluster 1 demonstrates how synergy between technological innovations and heightened consumer awareness drives transparency for social sustainability in fashion and textile supply chains. Achieving social sustainability within the fashion and textile realm requires an integrative approach that harnesses technological progress, collaborative frameworks, and ethically informed consumer engagement. Pereira et al. (2022) emphasised the role of artificial intelligence-driven customer models for better personalised decision making. Complementing this, technologies such as Blockchain, RFID, and mobile applications have been identified as critical enablers for achieving transparency and traceability across production networks (Khan et al. 2021; Jaska et al. 2022). Garcia-Torres et al. (2022) recognise the vitality of transparency and traceability to improve social, environmental and economic goals. Contrary, Hohn and Durach (2021) caution that technological systems can reinforce buyer dominance and intensify supplier vulnerability if not implemented equitably. To address this issue Nayak et al. (2022) proposed to integrate cultural heritage with innovation thereby improving social equity in regional contexts. Similarly, Yaghin

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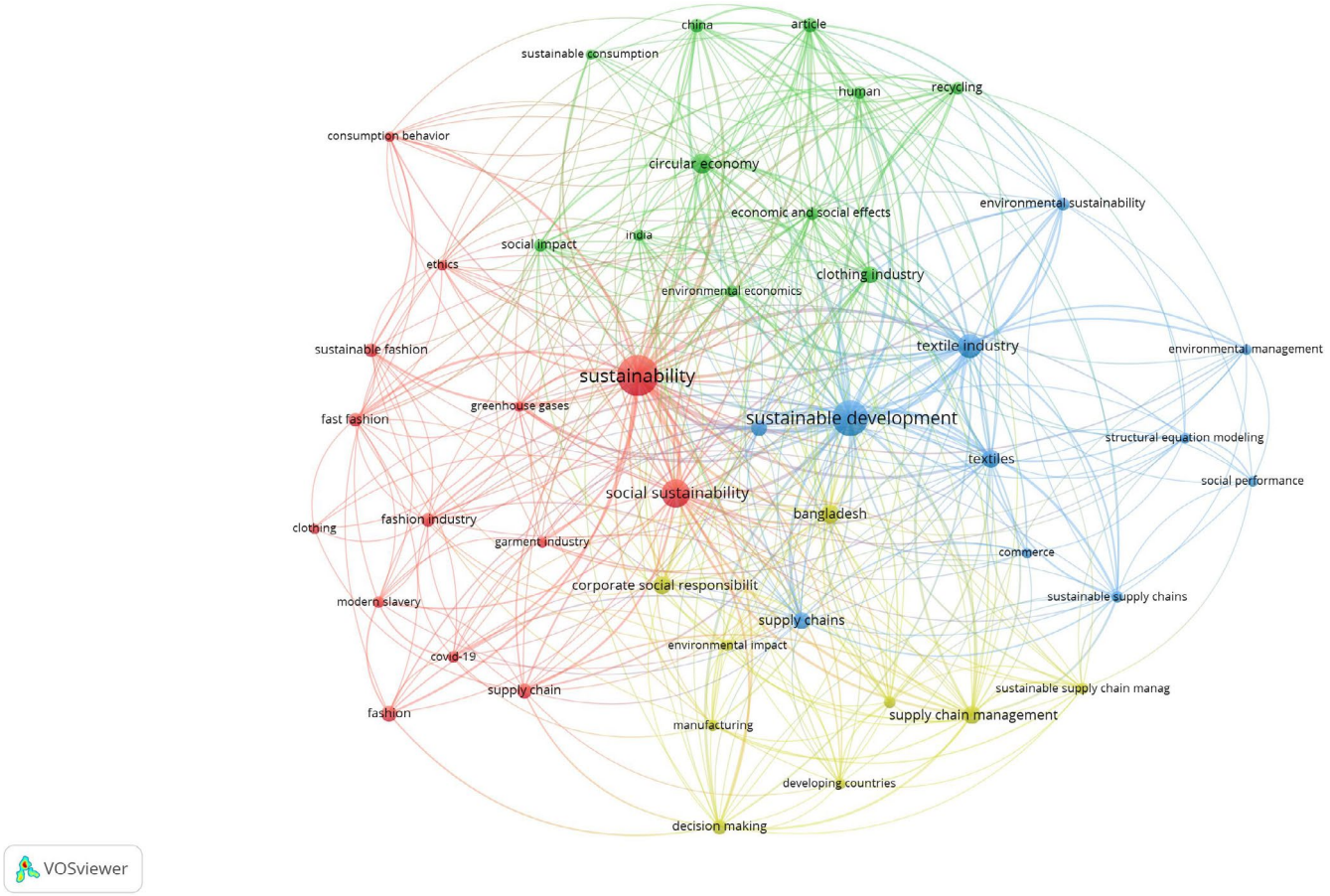


FIGURE 4 | The cluster diagram of co-occurrence of keywords between 2019 and 2023.

and Sarlak (2021) emphasise the importance of collaborative multi-stakeholder engagement and adaptive technology adoption as key mechanisms to reconcile economic efficiency with ethical imperatives. Collectively, these findings underscore that technology, while transformative, must be guided by inclusivity and shared responsibility to truly advance social equity in fashion.

4.2.2 | Cluster 2—Circular Synergies—Social Inclusion in Sustainable Models

Cluster 2 underscores the growing intersection between circular economy practices and social inclusion within the fashion and textile sector. Social sustainability has evolved from an ethical obligation to a strategic pillar supported by innovation in circular business models. Ostermann et al. (2021) highlighted that startups implementing Business Model Innovations for Circular Economy (BMI4CE) are transforming traditional supply chains into closed-loop systems that reduce waste while fostering social responsibility. Similarly, Clube and Tennant (2022) demonstrated how circular initiatives in Vietnam integrated social inclusion by employing individuals with disabilities and prioritising human welfare in tandem with ecological goals. However, Repp et al. (2021) caution that the circular transition has produced uneven global outcomes, with job losses in non-EU manufacturing sectors contrasted by employment growth in recycling and reuse industries within the EU. This highlighted the unequal global effects of such transformations. Rovanto and Bask (2021) further contend that the depth of circular implementation varies across firms, reflecting disparities in strategic commitment and stakeholder engagement. Collectively, these studies suggest that aligning circular innovation with equitable social outcomes is not merely desirable but essential for achieving a genuinely sustainable fashion and textile ecosystem.

4.2.3 | Cluster 3—Governance for Social Compliance and Ethical Sourcing

Cluster 3 underscores the pivotal role of governance and regulatory mechanisms in promoting ethical sourcing and ensuring social compliance across fashion supply chains. Bubicz et al. (2021) argue that while leading brands exert significant pressure on upstream suppliers to maintain social compliance, these efforts often coexist with persistent cost-reduction strategies that undermine genuine progress. Although initiatives advocating for fair wages, humane working conditions, and product responsibility have proliferated, implementation gaps and weak monitoring remain critical obstacles. Venkatesh et al. (2020) recognise that establishing strategic partnerships between buyers and sub-suppliers may help resolve the issue of non-compliance of sub-suppliers. They indicate that relentless price pressures and weak institutional enforcement limit such efforts, especially in developing economies. Bhandari et al. (2022) outlined significant challenges to sustainable sourcing within

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the luxury apparel industry, highlighting the importance of top management commitment, government support, and the availability of sustainable raw materials as key challenges. Similarly, Palgunadi et al. (2022) highlight the role of government in facilitating green business models in the Indonesian garment industry. Government intervention is needed to support domestic raw material procurement, streamline license processing, and provide financial incentives to support the high cost of implementing sustainability initiatives. Crinis (2019) provocatively argues that while CSR initiatives may address the issue of child labour, they fail to empower workers to form unions, addressing a deep labour rights issue. Collectively, these studies demonstrate that achieving genuine ethical sourcing requires robust governance, stronger government involvement, and multisectoral collaboration to fulfil the Sustainable Development Goals on decent work and economic growth.

4.2.4 | Cluster 4—Collaborative Pathways to Global Social Sustainability

Cluster 4 highlights the complexity of achieving social sustainability in global apparel supply chains and emphasises collaboration as a critical enabler of systemic change. Bhandari et al. (2022) identify management commitment, government support, and infrastructural limitations as major barriers that impede sustainable sourcing, alongside challenges in material selection, finance, and supplier capacity. Shaw et al. (2022) argue that the role of customer awareness and governance is important to overcome these challenges and effective implementation of sustainable fashion initiatives, in the Indian textile industry. Hur and Faragher-Siddall (2022) flagged the need for more transparency to address the problem of low eco-literacy and customer scepticism towards the fashion industry's sustainability claims, urging education-focused initiatives among young consumers in the UK. Rahman et al. (2021) highlight that sustainability preferences are shaped by cultural contexts, with Indian consumers showing higher sensitivity to ethical concerns, while Canadian buyers prioritise functionality and design. Fuchs and Hovemann (2022) argue that social sustainability and functional performance are given preference over circular product attributes for sporting products in the European market. These insights collectively suggest that achieving global social sustainability requires aligning organisational strategies with local expectations and embedding collaborative frameworks. Furthermore, Alblowi et al. (2022) revealed the importance of supply chain collaboration in promoting ethical practices. Collaborative initiatives, such as proactive responses to emergencies like COVID-19, helped enhance worker safety and economic assistance. Moreover, innovative frameworks such as the Shades of Green model (Turunen and Halme 2021) and formalisation methodologies (Nascimento and Silva 2020) illustrated their potential to yield actionable insights concerning sustainability and improve labour conditions. Despite the presence of challenges such as lack of managerial commitment and a siloed approach, the integration of social sustainability concepts with an operational framework provides promising pathways for systemic reforms (Hasle and Vang 2021). This integration is evidenced in circular fashion services and collaborative consumption models (Ramkumar et al. 2021; Cocquyt et al. 2020).

To answer research question 1, Table 1 provides a comparative synthesis illustrating how the discourse has shifted from firm-centric and compliance-oriented approaches towards more systemic, multi-stakeholder, and innovation-led models. This evolution mirrors broader global developments such as regulatory advancements, digitalisation, and the mainstreaming of sustainability within corporate strategy. By comparing these two periods, Table 1 highlights the intellectual and practical progression from moral responsibility to strategic co-governance, reflecting a maturing understanding of social sustainability as both an ethical imperative and a competitive enabler in global fashion supply chains.

5 | Discussion and Implications

5.1 | Discussion

Building on the thematic clusters identified in Section 4, which trace the shift from compliance-focused governance in the post-MFA era to technology-enabled collaboration in the post-MSA period, this discussion interprets that progression through the dual lenses of Institutional Theory and Stakeholder Theory. Institutional Theory captures the external pressures that drive firms to conform to regulatory and normative expectations, while Stakeholder Theory explains the internal and relational mechanisms through which firms engage multiple actors to build legitimacy and co-create value. Within this synthesis, worker voice emerges as the pivotal linking mechanism that connects institutional constraints with stakeholder responsiveness, explaining how regulatory mandates and engagement processes translate into tangible, on-the-ground improvements in labour practices and governance within global fashion supply chains.

Together, these theoretical perspectives form the foundation of the proposed conceptual model. Institutional Theory explains why organisations are compelled to act in response to external norms and formalised governance, whereas Stakeholder Theory reveals how they act through inclusive governance, transparency, and joint accountability. This integration bridges structural and relational perspectives, showing that institutional compulsion and stakeholder collaboration are not opposing forces but complementary pathways that collectively drive transformation from compliance to collaboration. Central to this dual-theoretical integration is the concept of worker voice, defined as the ability of workers to come together, collectively articulate their demands, and seek better terms and conditions of work, including fair wages, safe environments, and equitable treatment (Stephens et al. 2024). Rather than positioning worker voice merely as an outcome of inclusion, this study frames it as a pivotal mechanism for enacting social sustainability. Institutional Theory determines how regulatory, and normative pressures determine when and how workers can express their voice, such as through mandated reporting under Modern Slavery Acts or union protections in multi-stakeholder accords. In contrast, Stakeholder Theory highlights how stakeholder salience influences whether firms listen and respond, prioritising voices based on power, legitimacy, and urgency. Positioning worker voice in this way underscores that social sustainability is both top-down, shaped by regulatory structures, and bottom-up, enacted through worker participation.

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TABLE 1 | Evolution of social sustainability research themes in fashion and textiles (2005–2018 to 2019–2023).

Focus dimension	2005–2018: Foundational integration phase	2019–2023: Transformative collaboration phase	Conceptual transition/ emerging direction
Strategic orientation	Focused on embedding social responsibility within corporate systems through internal CSR policies, supplier codes of conduct, and life-cycle assessments. The emphasis was on building ethical legitimacy and aligning corporate behaviour with emerging sustainability norms.	The industry began adopting digital technologies such as AI, blockchain, and RFID to enhance traceability and social equity, reflecting a broader shift towards data-driven governance and accountability.	Movement from internal compliance and CSR rhetoric to technology-enabled transparency and external accountability.
Economic logic	Attempted to align ethical responsibility with profitability while confronting tensions between cost efficiency and fair labour practices. Firms sought legitimacy but often prioritised economic outcomes over long-term ethical commitments.	Circular economy principles integrated social inclusion and employment generation within sustainability models, linking human welfare with ecological regeneration.	Shift from ethics as cost burden to ethics as innovation, where circular and inclusive business models create shared value.
Governance mechanisms	Relied on voluntary codes and buyer-driven compliance initiatives with limited regulatory intervention. Multi-tier governance challenges remained unresolved due to power asymmetries and fragmented oversight.	Emergence of legislation and cross-sector initiatives institutionalised ethical sourcing and human rights compliance. Governments, industry coalitions, and NGOs collectively shaped governance standards.	Transition from self-regulation to legislated, multi-actor governance structures promoting systemic accountability.
Collaborative frameworks	Early collective efforts emerged, such as industry associations and certification schemes, to establish ethical baselines and harmonised standards across global supply chains.	Collaboration evolved into multi-stakeholder networks involving brands, unions, and policymakers. These partnerships advanced crisis response, transparency, and shared governance mechanisms.	Evolution from narrow industry coalitions to global co-governance ecosystems integrating shared accountability and SDG alignment.
Knowledge trajectory	Research centred on ethical sourcing, responsible production, and CSR-led frameworks focusing on foundational social and environmental dimensions.	Research shifted to socio-technological integration, exploring transparency, circularity, and digital accountability within global networks.	Theoretical convergence from moral legitimacy towards distributed accountability combining institutional and stakeholder perspectives.

Drawing on these insights, this paper proposes a systematic 2×2 framework (Figure 5) that maps the temporal and strategic evolution of social sustainability between 2005 and 2018 and 2019 and 2023. The horizontal axis represents the strategic orientation, a shift from a reactive compliance-driven approach (left) to proactive innovative strategies (right). The vertical axis represents a scope of engagement, a shift from firm-centric, intra-supply chain efforts (bottom) to collaborative, industry-wide initiatives (top). Together, these dimensions illustrate how the field has evolved from internal CSR compliance to transparent, collaborative, and technology-augmented governance. The framework thus integrates regulatory evolution, stakeholder engagement, and worker voice into a unified model of social sustainability transformation.

Finally, the model captures a causal progression in which institutional and stakeholder pressures trigger strategic shifts in firm behaviour, leading to distinct thematic outcomes in social sustainability. Along the horizontal dimension, institutional pressures, initially coercive and later normative, drive firms from reactive compliance towards proactive innovation. Along the vertical dimension, stakeholder interactions, based on power, legitimacy, and salience, broaden the scope of engagement from firm-centric initiatives to collaborative, industry-wide governance. The intersections of these causal forces across the four quadrants illustrate how regulation serves as a catalyst for strategic transformation, while collaboration and worker voice determine the depth and durability of change.

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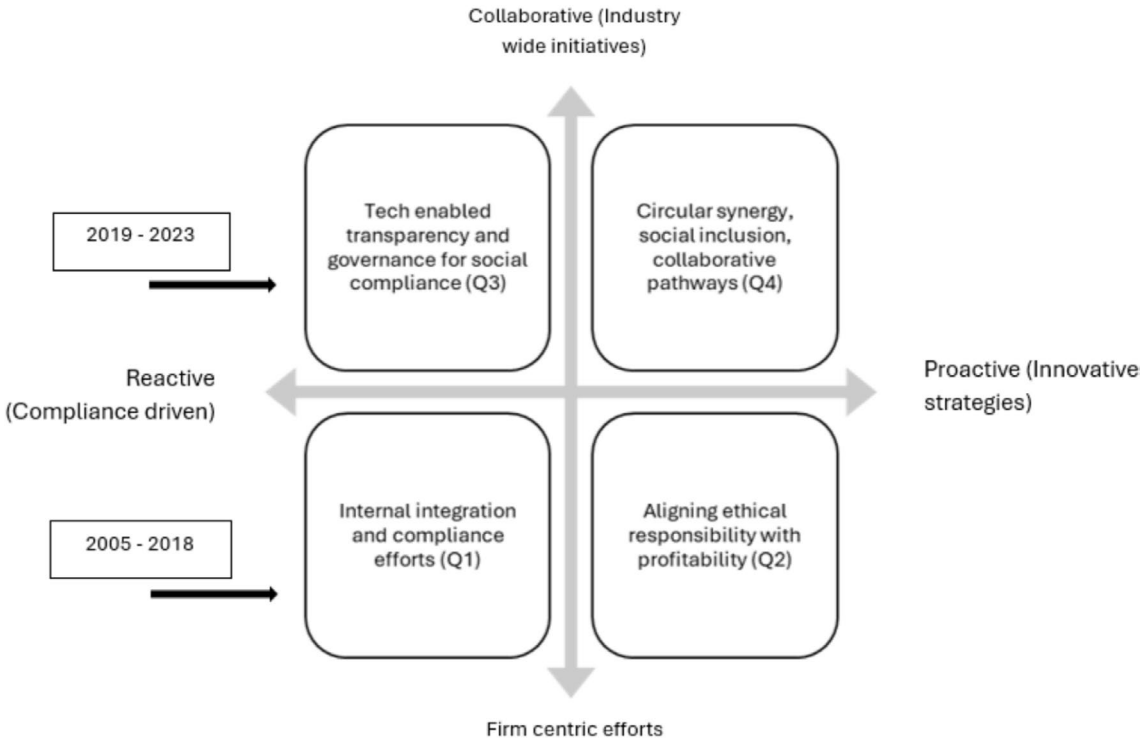


FIGURE 5 | Conceptual model representing thematic development of social sustainability.

5.1.1 | Quadrant 1—Integrating Social Sustainability in Corporate Fashion Systems (2005–2018)

The period between 2005 and 2018 marked the early institutionalisation of social sustainability within global fashion supply chains. Following the sweatshop scandals of the 1990s and the abolition of the Multi-Fibre Arrangement in 2005, brands were compelled to formalise internal systems of social responsibility to mitigate reputational and operational risks (Teibel 2018). The growing visibility of unethical labour practices placed coercive pressure on multinational buyers to establish codes of conduct, audit mechanisms, and supplier monitoring programmes. From the perspective of Institutional Theory, these actions reflected a phase of coercive isomorphism, where firms complied with emerging social norms and governance expectations primarily to retain legitimacy (DiMaggio and Powell 1983; Scott 2013).

The strategic intent during this period was predominantly reactive and compliance-driven. Companies such as Nike and H&M created internal CSR departments and auditing divisions to ensure adherence to ethical sourcing standards (Chan et al. 2020). Industry-wide schemes like the Fair Labor Association and SA8000 certification further reinforced normative alignment, institutionalising minimal labour standards across supplier networks. While these frameworks promoted procedural conformity, their underlying motivation was often defensive rather than transformative. Firms sought to avoid reputational damage rather than advance worker welfare, a tendency consistent with the early stages of institutional adaptation.

At the same time, Stakeholder Theory provides a useful counterbalance to this interpretation. Although firms primarily acted in response to institutional pressure, early stakeholder engagement began to shape the discourse around social performance. Codes of conduct were frequently developed in consultation with NGOs and labour groups, marking the first step towards recognising non-shareholder voices as legitimate stakeholders (Freeman 1984; Donaldson and Preston 1995). However, engagement remained largely symbolic and limited to first-tier suppliers. As Lund-Thomsen and Lindgreen (2014) argue, the persistent power asymmetry between Western buyers and suppliers in developing economies constrained meaningful change. Low pricing pressures and unstable contracts made compliance difficult to sustain, forcing suppliers to prioritise cost-cutting over social improvement.

This period revealed an inherent contradiction: while institutional mechanisms succeeded in embedding formal policies, they simultaneously reinforced a compliance culture that overlooked structural inequities. Auditing and certification processes focused on surface-level violations, yet they often failed to detect or remedy deeper issues such as excessive overtime, verbal harassment, and wage suppression (Alghababsheh and Gallear 2022). These limitations underscore the argument that voluntary compliance, though foundational, is insufficient without redistributive stakeholder engagement and shared accountability. In addition, despite several advancements, this phase remained firm-centric. While companies internalised social goals, structural inequalities such as low regional wages and weak labour protections persisted beyond corporate control.

Based on the discussion above the following proposition is offered as testable hypotheses for future empirical investigation:

Testable Proposition 1. *Reactive compliance-oriented strategies build foundational legitimacy but yield limited impact without stakeholder engagement and long-term institutionalisation.*

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5.1.2 | Quadrant 2—Aligning Ethical Responsibility With Profitability (2005–2018)

During the 2005–2018 period, many fashion firms began to move beyond compliance and recognise that social sustainability could generate tangible business value. This marked a strategic shift from coercive institutional conformity towards normative commitment, where firms sought legitimacy not merely through adherence to rules but by embedding ethical responsibility within business strategy. From an Institutional Theory standpoint, this transition represents a shift from coercive to normative isomorphism (DiMaggio and Powell 1983; Scott 2013), as firms internalised social norms into their organisational routines. Instead of reacting defensively to external scrutiny, they reframed social responsibility as a driver of performance and innovation.

Evidence supports that this strategic reframing produced measurable outcomes. Studies such as Duong (2022) demonstrated a positive relationship between social sustainability initiatives and supply chain performance metrics. The ILO's Better Work Program in Vietnam similarly revealed that firms investing in worker well-being reported notable gains in productivity and efficiency (International Labour Organization 2016). Production lines managed by socially trained supervisors experienced a 22% increase in productivity, illustrating how ethical investments could also enhance operational results. Such findings challenge the earlier assumption that social responsibility was an economic burden, instead suggesting that ethical practice could yield a competitive advantage.

From the lens of Stakeholder Theory, this shift also indicates growing recognition that addressing employee welfare, supplier equity, and community well-being contributes to long-term relational capital (Freeman 1984). Companies began experimenting with social sustainability innovations such as workforce skill development, health initiatives, and supplier partnerships (Hoque et al. 2022; Venkatesh et al. 2020). Brands like Patagonia and Nike exemplified this shift: Patagonia's participation in Fair Trade USA's programme demonstrated how paying premium wages strengthened both brand reputation and consumer loyalty (Fair Trade USA 2013), while Nike's post-crisis reforms in the 2000s underscored how transparency could restore trust (Baker 2016).

However, despite these advances, firm-centric initiatives remained limited in addressing systemic inequities such as regionally suppressed wages and fragmented subcontracting structures. While internal reforms improved accountability, they did little to alter broader labour regimes. Thus, this phase reveals both progress and constraint: social sustainability became strategically integrated yet remained bounded by firm-level control.

Based on the discussion above we make the following proposition as testable hypotheses for future empirical investigation:

Testable Proposition 2. *Proactive firm-centric sustainability strategies strengthen legitimacy and competitive advantage by aligning ethical responsibility with business value, but their transformative potential remains constrained without industry-wide coordination.*

5.1.3 | Quadrant 3—Tech Enabled Transparency and Governance for Social Compliance—(2019–2023)

Between 2019 and 2023, the global fashion industry witnessed a decisive shift towards transparency and governance, marking a transition from internal compliance to externally verifiable accountability. This phase reflected the institutional maturation of social sustainability, where coercive pressures from regulatory mandates converged with normative stakeholder expectations for openness and traceability. From the lens of Institutional Theory, these developments signify an evolution from voluntary codes to formalised regulatory enforcement, as exemplified by the introduction of the UK Modern Slavery Act (2015), the Australian Modern Slavery Act (2018), and the proposed EU Directive on Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence. These legislative frameworks compelled firms to disclose anti-slavery measures, transforming social responsibility from moral obligation into a regulatory necessity (Commonwealth of Australia, 2018; UK Home Office 2015). Such mandates represented a clear institutional shift, embedding social due diligence within corporate governance structures.

At the same time, Stakeholder Theory explains how these regulatory demands were reinforced by the collective expectations of investors, consumers, and civil society actors who increasingly demanded verifiable transparency. Brands such as H&M, Puma, and Levi's began disclosing factory lists and audit outcomes, signalling a growing acceptance that reputational legitimacy depended on openness (Human Rights Watch 2017). The adoption of digital traceability technologies—including blockchain, RFID systems, and AI-driven auditing tools—further operationalised this accountability, allowing real-time visibility across supply chain tiers. Studies such as Badhwar et al. (2023) demonstrated that blockchain improved verification accuracy, while mobile survey platforms like LaborVoices and Better Work facilitated worker feedback loops (Arora and Thompson 2019). These innovations transformed information asymmetry into shared accountability, reflecting an emerging alignment between institutional compliance and stakeholder empowerment.

Importantly, this phase also reflected a deeper institutional reconfiguration of governance. Multi-stakeholder accords and quasi-regulatory frameworks such as the Bangladesh Accord on Fire and Building Safety (2013–2018) continued to influence this period, establishing legally binding standards that extended beyond corporate voluntarism (Salminen 2018). The subsequent International Accord (2021) institutionalised these gains, embedding enforceable commitments across geographies (International Accord 2021). Together, these developments marked a structural transformation of governance from unilateral monitoring to collective regulation.

Thus, Quadrant 3 captures the consolidation of institutional legitimacy through regulatory compliance and technological transparency. Firms were no longer judged solely on intent but on verifiable performance.

This discussion is summarised by the following testable propositions:

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Testable Proposition 3. *Strengthened regulation and the diffusion of transparency-enabling technologies redefined corporate legitimacy in fashion supply chains, institutionalising collaborative governance and expanding stakeholder accountability.*

5.1.4 | Quadrant 4—Circular Synergies, Social Inclusion and Collaborative Pathways

The 2019–2023 period marked a decisive shift towards global, multi-stakeholder collaboration as the fashion industry began to reimagine social sustainability through innovation and inclusivity. This quadrant represents a phase of proactive institutional transformation, where firms, NGOs, unions, and governments jointly pursued systemic reform rather than isolated compliance. The momentum of this transition was reinforced by the Institutional Theory premise that sustained legitimacy depends not only on adherence to norms but also on collective institutional innovation (Scott 2013). Simultaneously, Stakeholder Theory underscores that complex sustainability challenges require distributed governance—where diverse actors co-create solutions beyond firm boundaries (Freeman 1984; Donaldson and Preston 1995).

Within this context, the rise of the circular economy became a key driver of socially inclusive innovation. Earlier sustainability efforts emphasised environmental efficiency; however, emerging frameworks began to integrate social equity as an intrinsic component of circularity (Circle Economy Foundation 2024). Initiatives such as those established by the manufacturer Saitex, which employs and trains people with disabilities in denim recycling, epitomise this dual focus on waste reduction and social empowerment (O'Connell 2020). Similarly, collaborations between luxury brands and artisan cooperatives demonstrate how circular models can redistribute value by generating livelihoods for marginalised craft communities (Thorisdottir and Johannsdottir 2020). These examples highlight that circular innovation, when socially embedded, functions not only as a technical fix but also as a mechanism for addressing inequality and exclusion across the supply chain.

The period also witnessed unprecedented growth in cross-sector alliances aimed at advancing decent work and equity, aligned with SDG 8 (Decent Work) and SDG 17 (Partnerships for the Goals). Initiatives such as the Global Fashion Agenda and the ACT (Action, Collaboration, Transformation) framework illustrate how collective bargaining and shared accountability can streamline governance, influence wage fairness, and foster crisis responses, such as during COVID-19, without siloed efforts, thereby integrating collaboration as a core driver of systemic reform (ACT Foundation n.d.). The ongoing evolution of the Bangladesh Accord into the International Accord (2021) further institutionalised these cooperative governance structures, transforming voluntary participation into enforceable commitments (Donaghey and Reinecke 2018; International Accord 2021).

While outcomes varied, these initiatives reflect a broader institutional convergence where stakeholder participation became a condition for legitimacy. In this sense, Quadrant 4 suggests the beginnings of a paradigm shift: from regulatory reaction to collaborative innovation, from isolated compliance to shared stewardship.

Thus, we can propose:

Testable Proposition 4. *Multi-stakeholder Initiatives (MSIs) as collaborative innovations have emerged as important mechanisms for addressing systemic social sustainability challenges within global fashion supply chains.*

Collectively, the four quadrants reveal the interplay of distinct but interlinked mechanisms that have driven the evolution of social sustainability in fashion supply chains. From an institutional perspective, coercive pressures in the form of mandatory audits, modern slavery legislation and international accords initially compelled firms to adopt compliance frameworks, as reflected in Quadrant 1. These gradually evolved into normative pressures as social expectations and professional standards normalised ethical responsibility as a core business value, illustrated in Quadrant 2. By the post-2019 period, mimetic pressures became evident as firms began to emulate best practices in transparency and circular innovation to maintain legitimacy within their peer networks, as seen in Quadrants 3 and 4.

In parallel, stakeholder mechanisms shaped how firms operationalised these institutional forces. These mechanisms rest on the assumption that the power of buyers, regulators and consumers reinforces accountability. Legitimacy can be achieved through transparent reporting and inclusive governance. The salience of worker welfare and social equity concerns has prompted collective action, particularly among the world's largest brands, retailers, manufacturers with unions and NGOs. Together, these mechanisms explain the shift from externally imposed compliance to co-created, legitimacy-based governance systems, showing the fashion industry's gradual movement from reactive adaptation to proactive institutional innovation. However, despite the positive trend demonstrated through the literature, questions remain as to how stakeholders within MSIs balance competing pressures between market demands and ethical values, as explored by Riisgaard et al. (2020). Critics of MSIs question their effectiveness in addressing social sustainability and argue for approaches that acknowledge and balance the power of corporations within the MSIs and seek means to amplify worker voice (Frishling 2023). The shift to government-mandated human rights due diligence, beyond MSIs, is likely to further reshape the field in the second half of the 21st century.

Overall, the conceptual framework illustrates how the interaction of institutional pressures and stakeholder collaboration has progressively redefined social sustainability, from reactive compliance to proactive collaboration, marking a paradigm shift towards co-governance and shared accountability.

5.2 | Theoretical Contributions

This research contributes to theory by bridging structural and relational perspectives on sustainability. Institutional Theory explains how coercive, normative, and mimetic pressures drive organisations to adopt socially responsible practices, while

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Stakeholder Theory reveals how engagement and shared accountability sustain these practices over time. The proposed framework extends existing scholarship by demonstrating that institutional legitimacy and stakeholder collaboration are complementary rather than sequential. It introduces a dynamic model where firms progress from compliance-based legitimacy (Quadrant 1) to proactive collaboration and innovation (Quadrant 4). This synthesis enhances theoretical clarity on how firms internalise social norms and translate them into governance mechanisms that generate both legitimacy and shared value. The testable propositions derived from each quadrant provide a foundation for future empirical work examining the causal links between regulation, technology, and collaborative innovation in sustaining ethical supply chains.

5.3 | Managerial Implications

For practitioners, the findings underscore that social sustainability must be integrated into the strategic and operational core of fashion businesses. Managers should move beyond symbolic compliance and adopt a performance-based view of ethics, where fair labour practices, worker welfare, and supplier partnerships are seen as drivers of efficiency and brand equity. Managers should also take concrete steps to enable worker representation and voice in their supply chains, as this is key to sustained improvements. For example, H&M's Global Framework Agreement with the global union IndustriALL created a mechanism to empower workers in around 1000 supplier factories. The updated agreement commits to promoting collective bargaining at the factory and industry levels and ensures that worker representatives are not discriminated against and can carry out their functions freely (Business and Human Rights Resource Centre 2024) By actively using its leverage to uphold freedom of association, H&M has institutionalised worker voice in its sustainability governance. Such initiatives illustrate how giving workers a seat at the table, through unions, worker committees, or grievance systems, can lead to more responsive and resilient supply chains.

Digital transparency tools such as blockchain and AI auditing should be leveraged to enhance traceability and accountability across multi-tiered supply chains in order for mandatory government due diligence requirements to be enforced. Furthermore, firms should prioritise long-term supplier development, a focus on worker voice and empowerment, equitable contracting, and shared investment in social compliance rather than relying solely on audits. By participating in collaborative initiatives such as the International Accord or ACT, firms can mitigate systemic risks and collectively elevate industry standards.

5.4 | Policy Implications

For policymakers, the framework illustrates that regulation is most effective when complemented by multi-stakeholder participation and technological transparency. Governments should design adaptive regulatory frameworks that combine mandatory disclosure with incentives for innovation and collaboration. Policymakers can also play a direct role in amplifying worker voice. A notable example is Germany's 2023 Supply Chain Due Diligence Act, which mandates companies to establish complaint mechanisms accessible to workers throughout their supply chain (Norton Rose Fulbright 2024). Through an online reporting system available in multiple languages and allowing anonymous submissions, affected employees or stakeholders can report human rights violations without fear of retaliation. By legally requiring such grievance channels, regulators are ensuring that worker voices are heard and acted upon. Other governments and international bodies could adopt similar measures—for instance, including worker consultations in due diligence legislation or requiring that firms engage with worker representatives as part of their compliance audits. Embedding worker voice into policy frameworks this way helps transform on-paper rights into real-world practices, making social sustainability governance more inclusive and effective.

6 | Conclusion, Limitations and Future Research

This systematic literature review comprehensively analysed the evolution of social sustainability within the fashion industry over two significant time periods: 2005–2018 and 2019–2023. In 2005–2018, firm-centric, compliance-oriented CSR dominated: codes of conduct, audits, and buyer-driven monitoring built baseline legitimacy yet struggled to penetrate multi-tier networks or shift structural power asymmetries. In 2019–2023, modern slavery legislation and due-diligence regimes, together with transparency technologies (e.g., RFID, blockchain, worker-voice tools) and circular business models, catalysed a pivot towards proactive, collaborative governance.

Framed by Institutional and Stakeholder theories, this study proposed a 2×2 model that explains this shift along two axes, strategic orientation (reactive to innovative) and scope of engagement (firm-centric to multi-stakeholder). The model yields four testable propositions that connect regulation, collaboration, and technology to social outcomes. These four propositions also establish substantive theoretical questions for future inquiry. Each proposition offers a basis to empirically test how institutional pressures (coercive, normative, and mimetic) interact with stakeholder salience (power, legitimacy, and urgency) to shape social sustainability outcomes. Future research could examine these dynamics across regions, firm sizes, and supply chain tiers to extend Institutional and Stakeholder Theory and assess how regulatory and collaborative mechanisms jointly influence long-term legitimacy and social value creation. For managers and policymakers, the implication is clear: isolated compliance is no longer sufficient. Co-governed, technology-enabled, circular, and worker-centred strategies represent the most promising pathways to achieve durable social performance within the fashion supply chain.

While significant efforts were made to ensure the validity and outcomes of the study process, it is important to acknowledge certain limitations. First, this study only relied upon peer-reviewed journals excluding other relevant publications. Restricting the analysis to English-language, peer-reviewed publications may have limited the inclusion of region-specific insights and practitioner-driven innovations reported in local or non-English

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outlets. This exclusion could potentially narrow the global representativeness of the findings, particularly for regions where fashion supply chain practices are documented primarily in domestic languages. Future research may adopt a more inclusive approach by incorporating grey literature and practitioner-based sources. Such inclusions would provide a more comprehensive understanding of applied social sustainability practices. Second, the implications of emerging technologies such as blockchain and AI are discussed in broad terms, but their specific impacts on social sustainability require further empirical investigation. Empirical studies are needed to examine how emerging technologies are being applied in diverse fashion supply chain contexts. Future research should focus on assessing whether technological interventions (e.g., blockchain for traceability, AI for labour risk prediction) effectively improve working conditions, ensure compliance, and amplify worker voice. Finally, this study concludes in 2023, thus excluding literature published in 2024 and beyond. This limitation may disregard recent progress amid continuing policy changes and advancements in ESG reporting practices. Future work should conduct longitudinal updates and comparative analyses to track how new regulations, stakeholder initiatives, and digital tools continue to reshape social sustainability in fashion supply chains.

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